

Scene 1: Oakshade Village

As dawn breaks over Oakshade Village, the party awakens to a town slowly coming to life. A hint of mist clings to the ground, casting an ethereal quality over the village square. People bustle quietly, going about their morning routines with wary glances at the surrounding forest. The innkeeper, Alwen, watches the party as they descend the stairs of The Old Oak Tavern, an approving gleam in her eye after yesterday's rumors of their feats in Eldridge Village.

Alwen, Tavern Keeper As they approach the bar for breakfast, Alwen greets them warmly. "Mornin', young ones! Word's already spreading about the lot of you. Folk around here could use a touch of bravery, I'll say that much," she nods with a knowing smile. As she sets down plates of bread and fresh berries, she lowers her voice, glancing around before continuing, "Say, you wouldn't be interested in the professor by any chance, would ya? Rumor is, you came looking for strange creatures. The professor's got his fair share, and then some!"

If the party asks about the professor, Alwen leans in, excited to share, her voice dropping to a hushed tone. "Professor Aelwyn's the name. A peculiar one, that fellow—studies critters and strange energies, says he's trying to understand what's been goin' on with the forest, why strange creatures keep popping up. He's got a place called **Ravenstone Laboratory** out in the wilds, but not many are brave enough to go looking."

Alwen glances towards the square. "If you're truly interested, you might want to talk to a few folks here in the village. Some've seen things, strange things, while he's been poking about."

Exploring the Village and Gathering Information

The party takes Alwen's suggestion, speaking with the locals to uncover more about the mysterious professor. As they walk through the square, they see people in small clusters, their voices hushed but curious, clearly aware of the recent disturbances in the woods.

Nina the Herbalist

Nina, an elderly herbalist with weathered hands and a warm smile, is tending her herb stall near the village's central well. She watches the party with a mixture of curiosity and relief as they approach.

"Ah, more brave souls! I hope you're here to help," she says, her voice calm but tinged with worry. "It's that forest, see? The air feels... different, heavy, like it's breathing. And I know that professor has something to do with it, bless him. I've seen the poor man come by in the dead of night, his arms full of odd things from the forest—stones, jars of glowing water, plants that don't grow here. Says he's studying it, but I say it's not for mortal minds to meddle in such things."

Nina hesitates, then continues in a low whisper, "I've heard he's been going further out, beyond where the trees are thickest. If he's right, and the planes themselves are shifting... well, it's no wonder strange creatures are finding their way here." She shudders. "Folk around here like to stay clear of such matters. I only hope he knows what he's dealing with."

Elder Merwin

The party soon spots Elder Merwin, a composed man with a weathered face and sharp eyes, speaking with a few villagers near the blacksmith's forge. When he notices the party's approach, he gives a slight nod, signaling his approval.

"You seek Professor Aelwyn, I hear," he says, his tone grave. "He's... well, he's brilliant, no doubt, but I'd say he's also a tad reckless. Always pushing the boundaries of what's safe to know, what's best left alone." Merwin gestures to the forest beyond the village. "The planes are delicate things. If he's right, and they're shifting, then we could see far worse than just strange creatures wandering in."

He glances at each of them. "Whatever's out there has already begun affecting the people here, making them uneasy, you see? If you find him, ask him how far he's willing to go. Tell him to remember what's at stake here. We can't afford for Oakshade to become a ground for planar... experimentation."

The Children's Whispers

As the party continues through Oakshade, they notice a group of children playing near the edge of the village, talking in excited but hushed voices. One of the children, a young girl with bright eyes, sees the party and darts over.

"You're looking for the professor, aren't you?" she asks, glancing nervously at the forest. "We see things at night—creatures, glowing lights. Some of them talk, even though there's nobody there." She shivers. "My mom says it's just stories, but we saw it with our own eyes—a floating shadow, whispering in the trees."

Another child pipes up, "One of 'em looked like a giant fox, all made of sparks! And another like a... like a big fluffy cloud." The children share uneasy looks before running off, leaving the party with a lingering sense of curiosity.

Meeting Tamsin, the Professor's Assistant

After the party has gathered information, they notice a figure approaching—**Tamsin**, a half-elf woman with a satchel and a determined look. She introduces herself quietly, scanning the square as she speaks. "You're asking after the professor, aren't you?" she says, her voice steady but carrying a hint of urgency. "Name's Tamsin. I work with him—sort of."

She hesitates, then continues, "Professor Aelwyn is studying what's happening out here, things most people wouldn't dare go near. He believes that the planar boundaries—the thin walls between our world and others—are shifting, letting in creatures from the Feywild, the Plane of Water, even the Plane of Shadow. He's been collecting samples, researching these... anomalies."

The Professor's Work

She pauses, as if choosing her words carefully. "He's devoted his life to studying the planes, but lately, it's become an obsession. He's holed up in **Ravenstone Laboratory** just outside the village, trying to find answers. If you're interested, I could mark it on your map, but... I'll warn you, the road's not safe."

Marking the Location

Tamsin takes a piece of parchment and marks Ravenstone Laboratory's location. "Just follow the western path out of the village and keep an eye out for a fork in the road. When you start feeling like the trees are watching, you're almost there," she says, giving a grim smile. "Just... be careful. He's dabbling with things that are as dangerous as they are fascinating."

Warning and Farewell

Before departing, Tamsin leaves them with a final thought. "The professor says these creatures are harmless, but I've seen the way some of them act, like they're... protecting something, almost. If he's right, and the planes are weakening, I don't know what we'll find, or how far it will go. But I know this much—whatever it is, it won't stop here."

With Tamsin's map in hand and a clear path laid out before them, the party feels the weight of the professor's work and the mystery they're stepping into. They set off, keenly aware that their journey holds secrets not just of strange creatures, but perhaps of the very fabric of the planes themselves.

Session 2, Act 1: Continuing the Journey from Oakshade Village

The party, now accompanied by Lickgloom, has gathered valuable information about the professor's work, the mysterious disturbances, and their possible connection to the planar creatures they've encountered. With the lab's location marked on their map by Tamsin, they leave Oakshade Village, setting out on a path that grows increasingly eerie as they venture deeper into the forested wilderness.

1. Scene: Leaving Oakshade Village

Setting: Oakshade's village square as dawn breaks, casting a golden light over the quiet village.

The players pack up, taking one last look at Oakshade before heading out. Alwen, the tavern keeper, waves from her door with a warm, "Good luck to you! And watch out for the strange ones out there!" Villagers nod respectfully as they pass, clearly relieved to have someone braving the forest in search of answers.

Encounter 2: Ambush by Mudskips (Combat, CR 4)

Setting:

A half-mile outside Oakshade Village, the forest thickens, and the path becomes soggy underfoot. Small streams trickle across the trail, and patches of mud become more frequent. The air is humid, and the sounds of bubbling water can be heard nearby. The party enters a clearing where the ground is saturated, forming shallow pools of murky water.

As they proceed, the surface of one of the larger pools ripples unnaturally. Suddenly, three small, amphibious creatures leap from the muddy waters. These creatures, known as **Mudskips**, resemble a cross between a salamander and a fish. They have slick, blue-green skin, fin-like appendages, and wide grins revealing rows of tiny, sharp teeth. Their eyes gleam with mischief and a hint of otherworldly energy.

Description of Mudskips:

- **Origin:** Mudskips are elemental creatures from the **Plane of Water**, drawn into the Material Plane due to weakening planar boundaries.
- **Behavior:** Playful yet territorial, they delight in causing trouble for unsuspecting travelers. They use the muddy terrain to their advantage, attempting to bog down and isolate their prey.

Combat Details:

Number of Creatures: 3 Mudskips

Tactics:

- **Terrain Manipulation:** The Mudskips use their abilities to create patches of slick mud, turning the battlefield into difficult terrain for the party while they move unhindered.
- **Hit-and-Run:** They dart in to attack and then retreat into the mud pools, using their swim speed to stay mobile.
- **Focus Fire:** The Mudskips may focus on characters who appear heavily armored or less mobile, trying to separate them from the group.

Dynamic Elements:

- **Environmental Hazards:** The muddy ground is difficult terrain for the party but not for the Mudskips.
- **Changing Battlefield:** The Mudskips can alter the terrain during combat, forcing the party to adapt their positioning.
- **Resource Management:** The encounter encourages players to use a variety of abilities, especially those that can counter terrain disadvantages or exploit the Mudskips' vulnerabilities.

Dynamic Encounter Elements:

- **Environmental Interaction:** The Mudskips can use **Mud Splash** to create additional areas of difficult terrain.
- **Strategic Movement:** Their ability to move freely through mud and water allows them to flank the party and target vulnerable characters.
- **Exploiting Weaknesses:** The Mudskips' resistance to fire forces Ursa and Lilly to adapt, perhaps encouraging them to use spells or abilities they don't typically rely on.

Narrative Element:

After the Mudskips are defeated, their bodies dissolve into puddles of muddy water, leaving behind small, shimmering **Motes of Water Energy**. These motes hover briefly before dissipating into the air, pulsating with a faint blue light.

- **Observation:** A character inspecting the motes can attempt an **Arcana** or **Nature** check (DC 13). On a success, they sense that these motes are fragments of elemental energy from the **Plane of Water**, further evidence of the weakening planar boundaries.

- **Potential Loot:** The party can collect **Elemental Mud Samples**, which may be useful for crafting or as material components for spells. These samples might also be of interest to Professor Aelwyn.
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Experience and Rewards:

- **Experience Points:** Defeating the Mudskips grants a total of 300 XP, to be divided among party members.
 - **Potential Leads:** The encounter reinforces the theme of planar disturbances, providing a tangible link to the professor's research.
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Enhancing the Encounter:

- **Additional Hazards:** Include hidden mud pits or geysers that the Mudskips can trigger, adding an extra layer of challenge.
 - **Complications:** If the battle is going too easily, introduce a fourth Mudskip or have one attempt to flee, potentially leading the party into a trap or deeper into hazardous terrain.
 - **Role-Playing Opportunity:** If the party attempts to communicate, they might discern that the Mudskips are confused by their displacement from the Plane of Water, adding depth to the planar instability storyline.
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3. Encounter 2: Ambush on the Road - Rival Goblin Clan (Multi-creature Combat, CR 4)

Setting: A narrow, wooded path with dense brush on either side, perfect for an ambush.

As the party continues, the quiet sounds of nature are disrupted by the sudden crack of a branch snapping. They find themselves surrounded by members of a rival goblin clan—rough, hostile faces emerging from the shadows, each carrying primitive weapons. Their leader, a stocky goblin with a scar across his face, snarls when he spots Stabby.

“Well, if it isn’t one of the Bloodfang Clan, wandering far from home!” he sneers. “You’re bold, bringing friends. Shame they’ll make such a tasty meal!”

Combatants:

- **2 Goblins** armed with bows, lurking on either side of the path, aiming for the party from a distance.
- **1 Worg**, snarling and ready to pounce.

- **1 Orc** with a thick club, guarding the goblin boss.
- **1 Hobgoblin** wielding a crossbow, taking position further back to snipe at the players.
- **1 Goblin Boss** who coordinates the attack, barking orders at his underlings.

Combat Details:

- **Tactics:** The goblin boss directs the archers to focus on weaker party members, while the worg and orc engage in melee combat. The hobgoblin sniper provides cover fire from behind, offering Stabby a chance to use his “catch an arrow” reaction.
- **Challenges:** With both ranged and melee enemies, the party will need to balance their focus, making strategic choices to avoid becoming overwhelmed by the coordinated attack.

Narrative Element:

During the fight, the goblin boss taunts Stabby with insults about the Bloodfang Clan’s “weakness” and mocks him for leaving. The goblins are merciless, sparing no effort to intimidate the party, enhancing the tension of the scene. If defeated, the goblins retreat, muttering curses and leaving the party wary of future encounters with the Bloodfang Clan.

Encounter 4: Vision at the Whispering Glade

Setting:

After the intense encounters with the **Mudskips** and the rival goblin clan, the sun begins to set as the party continues along the forest path toward Ravenstone Laboratory. The path leads them to a serene clearing known locally as the **Whispering Glade**. The glade is encircled by ancient trees whose leaves rustle softly, even without wind, creating the illusion of whispers. At the center stands an old stone monument covered in moss and faintly glowing runes.

Narrative Development:

As the party steps into the glade, a sense of calm washes over them. The atmosphere feels different here—time seems to slow, and the usual sounds of the forest are muted. Lilly notices that the **Essence Sphere**, originally a power core for a battlemaster automaton gifted by her mother, begins to emit a soft hum and a faint glow. Ursa feels a warmth emanating from his **enchanted potatoes**, and his **Dragonmark** tingles subtly.

The Vision Unfolds:

- **Trigger Event:** Ursa feels an inexplicable pull toward the stone monument. As he places his hand on it, the runes illuminate, casting a gentle light across the glade. Simultaneously, the Essence Sphere in Lilly’s possession resonates, and the enchanted potatoes pulse in unison.

- **The Vision:** The surroundings fade, and the party finds themselves in a vast, ethereal expanse filled with swirling mists and shimmering lights. A figure emerges from the luminescence—a radiant **goddess-like entity** embodying nature and balance. Her form is composed of intertwining vines, starlight, and flowing water, and her eyes reflect the depths of the cosmos.

Elaria, Guardian of the Planes:

Elaria: "Seekers of truth, you have touched the threads that bind the realms. I am Elaria, guardian of the planes and the balance that sustains them. A great disturbance ripples through existence, and the boundaries between worlds grow thin."

She gazes upon Ursa:

Elaria: "Child of Ash, your father delved into mysteries that few dare to explore. The **enchanted potatoes** you carry are remnants of a shattered covenant—a safeguard against the unraveling. They hold the key to restoring what was lost."

Turning to Lilly:

Elaria: "Ingenious artificer, the **Essence Sphere** you bear, once a mere power core, now resonates with energies beyond its making. It has the potential to channel and stabilize the motes of wayward creatures caught between planes."

Finally, she addresses Stabby:

Elaria: "Wanderer of shadows, your path is interwoven with chaos and choice. Your actions may sway the tides toward harmony or deepen the discord."

Visions of elemental chaos, collapsing landscapes, and flickering images of creatures from various planes flash around them.

Elaria: "The planar disturbances are but a symptom of a greater malady. An ancient entity seeks to exploit this weakness, consuming the essence of worlds. Unite your strengths, restore the safeguards, and mend the fractures before all is lost."

- **Vision's End:** The ethereal scene dissipates, and the party finds themselves back in the Whispering Glade. Night has fallen, and the stars above shine with extraordinary brilliance. The runes on the monument gradually dim but leave a lingering glow that seems to resonate with their newfound purpose.

Character Reactions:

- **Ursa:** Overwhelmed by the revelation about his father and the significance of the enchanted potatoes.
Ursa: "My father was trying to protect the balance of the planes. These potatoes are more than heirlooms—they're vital to preventing a catastrophe. We have to finish what he started."
- **Lilly:** Realizing that the Essence Sphere's true potential goes beyond her initial understanding.
Lilly: "The power core wasn't just a gift—it was meant for this purpose. If it can help stabilize these planar energies, we might be able to save not only Pikachu but also prevent further chaos."
- **Stabby:** Pondering his role in the unfolding events.
Stabby: "Well, looks like causing a bit of chaos might actually help this time. Maybe it's time to see what happens when we shake things up for the better."

Gameplay Mechanics:

- **Boon from the Vision:**
 - **Ursa:** Gains the ability "**Planar Awareness**" for the next 24 hours, allowing him to detect planar anomalies within a 1-mile radius.
 - **Lilly:** The Essence Sphere now has the property "**Planar Attunement**", granting her advantage on Arcana checks related to planar magic and creatures.
 - **Stabby:** Receives "**Glimpse of Possibility**", granting advantage on his next saving throw or skill check.
- **Short Rest Opportunity:** The glade provides a safe haven where the party can take a short rest. During this time, they can discuss the vision, strategize, and recover.

Narrative Impact:

- **Advances the Main Plot:** The vision introduces Elaria and reveals that the planar disturbances are part of a larger threat orchestrated by an ancient entity seeking to consume planar essence.
- **Connects to Ursa's Father:** Confirms that Ash Catchum was involved in efforts to safeguard the planes and that his work is incomplete.
- **Highlights the Enchanted Potatoes and Essence Sphere:** Emphasizes their importance in restoring balance and hints at their latent powers.

Transition to the Next Scene:

As the party prepares to leave the Whispering Glade, they notice that the path ahead seems slightly different—as if subtly altered by their experience. They feel a renewed sense of purpose and urgency. The laboratory of Professor Aelwyn awaits, and they now have deeper questions that only he might answer.

Encounter 5: Battle with Terranox (Combat, CR 4)

Setting:

As the party continues their ascent toward **Ravenstone Laboratory**, the rocky terrain becomes increasingly rugged. The path narrows between steep cliffs, with loose stones underfoot. Suddenly, the ground begins to shake. With a deep, resonant rumble, **Terranox** emerges—a large, serpent-like creature composed of stone and earth. Its rocky scales glint in the fading sunlight, and its eyes glow with an inner magma-like light. Terranox blocks the path, regarding the party as intruders. There is no option for diplomacy; the creature immediately moves to attack.

Narrative Development:

Terranox is an elemental from the **Plane of Earth**, drawn into the Material Plane due to the weakening planar boundaries. It is aggressive and territorial, attacking anything that enters its domain.

Combat Tactics

- **Relentless Assault:** Terranox attacks the nearest intruders with ferocity, showing no mercy.
 - **Area Control:** Uses **Earthquake Stomp** to disrupt the party's formation, making movement difficult.
 - **Damage Resistance:** Its immunity to fire compels Ursa and Lilly to utilize alternative strategies, such as spells of different elements or support roles.
 - **Targeting:** Attempts to **Stone Coil** spellcasters or ranged attackers to neutralize them early in the fight.
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Narrative Outcome

- **Victory:**
Upon defeating Terranox, it collapses into a heap of inert stone and dust. Among the rubble, the party discovers an **Earth Mote**—a small, crystalline fragment pulsating with elemental energy. Holding it provides a sense of the raw power of the Plane of Earth.
 - **Defeat:**
If the party is overwhelmed, Terranox leaves them unconscious but alive, burrowing back into the ground afterward. They awaken later, injured but with an opportunity to recover.
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Loot

- **Earth Mote:** A valuable elemental essence useful for crafting, enhancing spells, or as a research aid for Professor Aelwyn.
 - **Stone Fragments:** Pieces of Terranox's body that can be used to create minor magical items or sold to collectors.
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Experience and Rewards

- **Combat Victory:** Award 1,100 XP (CR 4) divided among the party members.

Connection to the Greater Narrative

- **Planar Disturbances:**

The encounter emphasizes the dangers posed by the weakening planar boundaries, as powerful elemental creatures invade the Material Plane.

- **Insight for the Professor:**

The Earth Mote and the experience provide valuable information that could assist Professor Aelwyn in understanding and addressing the planar disruptions.

- **Character Development:**

- **Ursa:** Faces the tangible threats resulting from planar imbalance, reinforcing his commitment to restore balance.
- **Lilly:** Encouraged to think creatively and perhaps discover new uses for the Essence Sphere beyond fire-based applications.
- **Stabby:** An opportunity to demonstrate his combat prowess and agility against a formidable opponent.

Adjustments for Difficulty

- **Scaling Down:**

- Reduce Terranox's hit points to 75.
- Lower the saving throw DCs to 13.
- Limit **Stone Coil** to restraining without additional damage.

- **Scaling Up:**

- Increase hit points to 110.
- Add minor environmental hazards, such as small rockfalls during the battle.

Enhancing the Encounter

- **Environmental Hazards:**

The battlefield is littered with unstable rocks. Each round, there's a chance (e.g., roll a d6; on a 5–6) that loose rocks fall, requiring a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw to avoid 5 (1d10) bludgeoning damage.

- **Strategic Terrain:**

Use the rocky terrain to create natural cover or obstacles, forcing the party to consider positioning carefully.

- **Time Pressure:**

The sounds of battle may attract other creatures if it drags on, adding urgency to defeat Terranox quickly.

Conclusion

This encounter provides a challenging but appropriate combat scenario for a party facing a CR 4 creature. Terranox's immunity to fire damage forces Ursa and Lilly to adapt their usual tactics, promoting creative problem-solving. Stabby's abilities become crucial in maneuvering and dealing damage. The battle reinforces the campaign's themes of planar instability and sets the stage for meaningful interactions with Professor Aelwyn, who may offer insights or assistance based on the party's experiences.

Encounter 6: Arrival at Ravenstone Laboratory and Meeting Professor Aelwyn

Setting:

As twilight paints the sky with hues of orange and purple, the party finally reaches the crest of a wooded hill. Below them lies **Ravenstone Laboratory**, nestled in a tranquil valley surrounded by ancient oaks and shimmering ponds. The laboratory is an impressive structure of stone and glass, with turrets that spiral upwards like reaching fingers, capped with metallic domes that glint in the fading light. Soft lights emanate from within, casting a warm and inviting glow.

The path leading down is lined with peculiar, luminescent flowers that sway gently despite the still air. Small, whimsical creatures flutter among the trees—some with wings like leaves, others resembling tiny mammals with glowing markings. Their presence adds an air of enchantment to the surroundings.

Approach to the Laboratory:

Descending the path, the party notices that the creatures are not shy; a few approach cautiously, eyes bright with curiosity. One such creature, resembling a small fox with a leaf-like tail and ears, pads up to **Lilly** and sniffs inquisitively before darting back into the foliage.

Lilly's eyes sparkle with excitement. "Did you see that? I've never encountered wildlife like this before!"

Ursa nods thoughtfully. "There's something special about this place. It's as if the veil between worlds is thinner here."

Stabby grins. "Or maybe the critters just know a friendly face when they see one."

As they reach the grand wooden doors of the laboratory, they open smoothly on their own, revealing an inviting entrance hall. The scent of old books, fresh parchment, and a hint of ozone fills the air.

Inside the Laboratory:

The interior is a harmonious blend of natural elements and arcane craftsmanship. Wooden beams arch overhead, supporting a ceiling adorned with intricate murals of celestial bodies and mythical creatures. Shelves laden with books and artifacts line the walls, interspersed with large windows that offer views of the serene landscape outside.

But most striking are the numerous creatures moving about the space. They are unlike any the party has seen—each one unique yet sharing an aura of mystical energy. Some resemble animals imbued with elemental features: a rabbit with fur like blooming flowers, a bird with feathers that flicker like flames, and a turtle with a shell that seems to hold swirling water within.

One such creature, resembling a small dragon whelp with shimmering scales and tiny wings, flutters over to the party. It tilts its head, studying them with keen, intelligent eyes before chirping a melodious greeting.

Ursa smiles gently. "Hello there, little one."

The creature flutters its wings in response before darting off toward a spiral staircase.

Meeting Professor Aelwyn:

Following the creature's lead, the party ascends the staircase, which winds around a central atrium filled with hanging plants and softly glowing crystals. They arrive at an expansive study where walls of books stretch up to a domed ceiling painted to resemble the night sky, complete with twinkling stars and drifting clouds.

At a large wooden desk cluttered with open tomes, scrolls, and peculiar instruments, stands **Professor Aelwyn Ravenstone**. He is an elderly man with kind eyes, a neatly trimmed silver beard, and a warm smile. His attire is a comfortable blend of scholarly robes and practical garments suited for fieldwork.

He looks up as they enter, his eyes lighting up with genuine delight. "Ah, visitors! How wonderful. I don't get many these days."

Lilly steps forward eagerly. "Professor Aelwyn, it's an honor to meet you. I'm Lilly Glimmergear. These are my companions, Ursa Catchum and Stabby Sharpblade."

Aelwyn extends his hands in welcome. "Please, call me Aelwyn. Any friend of these marvelous creatures is a friend of mine."

He gestures around the room where several of the mystical creatures are perched—one curled up on a cushion, another nestled among the bookshelves, and a third observing from a chandelier with glittering eyes.

Dialogue and Description:

Aelwyn notices **Lickgloom** by **Ursa's** side—a creature resembling a playful blend of feline and plant, with tendrils that gently sway as if in an unseen breeze.

Aelwyn's eyes widen with fascination. "My word! Is that a Lickgloom you have there? I've only read about them in ancient texts. Remarkable!"

Ursa nods. "Yes, Lickgloom joined us on our journey. We've encountered several unusual creatures and phenomena recently."

Stabby chimes in. "You wouldn't believe the day we've had—mud creatures, rock serpents, and now this place. It's like stepping into a storybook."

Aelwyn chuckles warmly. "I can imagine. The world is full of wonders, especially now with the boundaries between realms becoming... flexible."

He motions for them to sit in comfortable chairs near a hearth where a gentle fire crackles, casting a cozy glow. A creature resembling a small, bipedal salamander with a flickering tail flame brings over a tray with steaming cups of herbal tea.

Lilly accepts a cup, her gaze never settling as she takes in every detail of the room. "Your laboratory is incredible. Are all these creatures native to this area?"

Aelwyn sips his tea thoughtfully. "Not originally. Many have appeared over the past few years. I believe they hail from adjacent planes or realms that are intersecting with ours. I've dedicated my research to studying them and understanding the shifts in our world's fabric."

Laboratory Description with Creatures:

The study is a treasure trove of knowledge and curiosities. Alongside the books and scrolls are glass cases containing peculiar artifacts and samples—crystals that pulse with inner light, vials of iridescent liquids, and fragments of materials that defy easy description.

Creatures of various shapes and sizes move freely, clearly at ease. Some examples include:

- A **leafy quadruped** with a budding flower on its back, tending to potted plants that bloom under its care.
- A **small, agile creature** with sparks dancing across its fur, playfully chasing motes of light that it conjures.
- A **serene amphibious being** with smooth blue skin and shell-like adornments, calmly shaping water in the air into delicate sculptures.

Ursa watches them with awe. "They're... beautiful. And they seem so at home here."

Aelwyn smiles gently. "They are extraordinary, aren't they? Each one is unique, possessing abilities that challenge our understanding of magic and nature."

Invitation to Rest:

As the conversation continues, **Aelwyn** notices the weariness in their expressions.

"Forgive me," he says, standing up. "You must be exhausted from your travels. I insist that you stay here tonight. There is much I'd like to discuss with you, especially given your experiences with these creatures."

Lilly glances at her companions, who nod in agreement. "Thank you, Professor. We appreciate your hospitality."

Aelwyn claps his hands softly, and a creature resembling a small, owl-like being with luminous eyes swoops down, hovering expectantly.

"Please show our guests to the guest quarters," he instructs. Turning back to the party, he adds, "Rest well. We'll have a hearty breakfast and ample time to delve into your adventures."

Guest Quarters:

The owl-like creature leads them through corridors adorned with tapestries depicting legendary creatures and landscapes from distant realms. The walls seem to subtly shift in color, reflecting the ambient magic of the place.

They arrive at a set of adjoining rooms, each tailored to provide comfort and tranquility. Soft beds with plush linens, windows overlooking the moonlit gardens, and gentle illumination from floating crystals create an atmosphere of peace.

On a small table in each room, a creature resembling a tiny, luminescent sprite flutters near a tray of refreshments—fresh fruit, bread, and cheeses—should they need a late-night snack.

Stabby flops onto his bed with a contented sigh. "Now this is more like it. Beats the hard ground any day."

Lilly gently touches a crystal lamp, watching it brighten at her touch. "The integration of magic into everyday convenience here is astounding."

Ursa stands by the window, gazing at the night sky where unfamiliar constellations twinkle. "I have a feeling tomorrow will bring the answers we've been seeking."

Closing Scene:

As they settle in for the night, the sounds of the laboratory create a soothing backdrop—the soft hum of arcane devices, the distant murmur of flowing water, and the occasional melodic call of the creatures residing within.

Each party member reflects on the journey that led them here—the challenges faced, the mysteries encountered, and the hope that **Professor Aelwyn** might illuminate the path forward.

The laboratory, with its wonders and welcoming aura, feels like a haven—a place where questions may find answers, and where new friendships may forge the way to restoring balance to their world.

Note:

- The professor is depicted as a kind and knowledgeable figure, mirroring the essence of a mentor deeply interested in the creatures and phenomena the party has encountered.
- The laboratory is enriched with descriptions of creatures that are inspired by mythical and elemental themes, integrated into the setting in a way that adds depth without relying on specific, copyrighted characters.
- Dialogue and interactions are designed to engage the players, setting the stage for the next session where more detailed discussions and plot developments will occur.
- The encounter concludes with the party being invited to rest, creating a natural pause in the narrative that builds anticipation for future revelations.

Mudskip Statblock

Mudskip

Small elemental, neutral

Armor Class: 13 (Natural Armor)

Hit Points: 22 (4d6 + 8)

Speed: 20 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	6 (−2)	12 (+1)	8 (−1)

Skills: Stealth +4, Perception +3

Damage Resistances: Fire

Damage Vulnerabilities: Lightning

Senses: Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 13

Languages: Understands Aquan but can't speak

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP each)

Traits

- **Amphibious:** The Mudskip can breathe air and water.
- **Mud Dweller:** The Mudskip ignores difficult terrain composed of mud or shallow water.
- **Slippery:** The Mudskip has advantage on ability checks and saving throws made to escape grapples.

Actions

- **Multiattack:** The Mudskip makes two attacks: one with its **Mud Spit** and one with its **Tail Slap**.
- **Mud Spit. Ranged Weapon Attack:** +4 to hit, range 30 ft., one target.
Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage. The target must succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or its movement speed is reduced by 10 feet until the end of its next turn.
- **Tail Slap. Melee Weapon Attack:** +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target.
Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) bludgeoning damage.
- **Mud Splash (Recharge 5–6):** The Mudskip creates a splash of mud in a 15-foot cone. Each creature in that area must make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 9 (2d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage and is **blinded** until the end of its next turn. On a successful save, the creature takes half damage and isn't blinded.

Terranox

Large elemental, unaligned

Armor Class: 16 (Natural Armor)

Hit Points: 95 (10d10 + 40)

Speed: 30 ft., burrow 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
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20 (+5)	10 (+0)	18 (+4)	5 (-3)	11 (+0)	6 (-2)
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Damage Resistances: Bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks not made with adamantite weapons

Damage Immunities: Fire, Poison

Condition Immunities: Exhaustion, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned, Prone

Senses: Darkvision 60 ft., Tremorsense 60 ft., Passive Perception 10

Challenge Rating: 4 (1,100 XP)

- **Earth Glide:** Terranox can burrow through nonmagical, unworked earth and stone. While doing so, it doesn't disturb the material it moves through.
 - **Siege Monster:** Terranox deals double damage to objects and structures.
 - **Elemental Resilience:** Terranox has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.
 - **Immutable Form:** Terranox is immune to any spell or effect that would alter its form.
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Actions

- **Multiattack:** Terranox makes two attacks: one with its **Bite** and one with its **Tail Slam**.
- **Bite. Melee Weapon Attack:** +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target.
Hit: 16 (2d10 + 5) piercing damage.
- **Tail Slam. Melee Weapon Attack:** +7 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target.
Hit: 13 (2d8 + 5) bludgeoning damage. The target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be **knocked prone**.
- **Stone Coil (Recharge 5–6):** Terranox attempts to grapple one creature within 10 feet. The target must make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, the creature is **grappled** (escape DC 15) and **restrained**. The target takes 9 (1d8 + 5) bludgeoning damage at the start of each of its turns until the grapple ends.
- **Earthquake Stomp (Recharge 6):** Terranox slams the ground, causing a tremor in a 20-foot radius. Each creature on the ground in that area must make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 14 (4d6) bludgeoning damage and is **knocked prone**. On a successful save, the creature takes half damage and isn't knocked prone.

GOBLIN BOSS

[Goblin, chef]

Small humanoid (Goblinoid), neutral evil

Armor Class 17 (chain shirt, shield)

Hit Points 21 (6d6)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	8 (-1)	10 (+0)

Skills Stealth +6

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 9

Languages Common, Goblin

Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Nimble Escape. The goblin can take the Disengage or Hide action as a bonus action on each of its turns.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The goblin makes two attacks with its scimitar. The second attack has disadvantage.

Scimitar. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) slashing damage.

Javelin. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 30/120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 3 (1d6) piercing damage.

REACTIONS

Redirect Attack. When a creature the goblin can see targets it with an attack, the goblin chooses another goblin within 5 feet of it. The two goblins swap places, and the chosen goblin becomes the target instead.

GOBLIN

[Goblin]

Small humanoid (Goblinoid), neutral evil

Armor Class 15 (leather armor, shield)

Hit Points 7 (2d6)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	8 (-1)	8 (-1)

Skills Stealth +6

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 9

Languages Common, Goblin

Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Nimble Escape. The goblin can take the Disengage or Hide action as a bonus action on each of its turns.

ACTIONS

Scimitar. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) slashing damage.

Shortbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 80/320 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Goblins are small, black-hearted humanoids that lair in despoiled dungeons and other dismal settings. Individually weak, they gather in large numbers to torment other creatures.

WORG

[Worg]

Large monstrosity, neutral evil

Armor Class 13 (natural armor)

Hit Points 26 (4d10 + 4)

Speed 50 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	13 (+1)	7 (-2)	11 (+0)	8 (-1)

Skills Perception +4

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14

Languages Goblin, Worg

Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Keen Hearing and Smell. The worg has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.

ACTIONS

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) piercing damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

ORC

[Orc]

Medium humanoid (Orc), chaotic evil

Armor Class 13 (hide armor)

Hit Points 15 (2d8 + 6)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	7 (-2)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills Intimidation +2

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages Common, Orc

Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Aggressive. As a bonus action, the orc can move up to its speed toward a hostile creature that it can see.

ACTIONS

Greataxe. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 (1d12 + 3) slashing damage.

Javelin. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 30/120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

HOBGOBLIN

[Hobgoblin]

Medium humanoid (Goblinoid), lawful evil

Armor Class 18 (chain mail, shield)

Hit Points 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13 (+1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	9 (-1)

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages Common, Goblin

Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Martial Advantage. Once per turn, the hobgoblin can deal an extra 7 (2d6) damage to a creature it hits with a weapon attack if that creature is within 5 feet of an ally of the hobgoblin that isn't incapacitated.

ACTIONS

Longsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) slashing damage, or 6 (1d10 + 1) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Longbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, range 150/600 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage.

Hobgoblins are large goblinoids with dark-orange or red-orange skin. A hobgoblin measures virtue by physical strength and martial prowess, caring about nothing except skill and cunning in battle.

